consumed by his own ambitions and instead of concentrating on changes, started playing politics. Pakistan needs a national think-tank of 40–50 of our finest: soldiers, politicians, business leaders, intellectuals, who should give the government advice and the government should take it seriously. And the government should always be run by civilians – honourable ones. Those are my two cents.

I have no political ambitions. Actually, that's not true. At the moment, I do not have political ambitions. I'm quite a serious fan of politics – I see it as a public service – but I don't think there's one, not one, political party that I can join at the moment. And frankly, if I try to create my own party, I will probably be kicked out by my party members. I'm terribly naïve.

About Mian Nawaz Sharif: he's a good guy. Once upon a time, I was actually very fond of him. He's a got a big heart. But he didn't learn much from all his time in and out of politics. His social media approach of late has been disastrous and has been divisive for Pakistan. He didn't use his fan following for the country or even his party. He used it all for himself. That's just wrong. And when he was being tried, he made it all about himself, not the country.

You know what a good leader does when in power? He reaches out to everyone. He asks the opposition for help and advice about how to improve things. He even goes and talks to the state's enemies if he has to. He doesn't shut them out. He doesn't shoo them off. If you've got millions of votes, you should have the confidence to work with people across parties and institutions. If you're really serious about running Pakistan, you need to work with the whole country.

It's sad – the whole political circus is a scam. The *jalsas*, the glitzy political rallies, are attended by the types who don't vote. Meanwhile, on polling day the votes go to the machines which have been running the country into the ground. So we end up with a government which behaves like Turkish leader Recep Tayyab Erdogan's, without any populist support. But with the 2018 elections and Imran Khan's advent, we've seen that change somewhat. I'm not sure if it's going to be sustainable.

You know what our greatest tragedy is? The lack of education. We don't read. We don't process. We don't analyse. We are not accountable. Consequently, our leaders just play politics, not serve the people. And you know who is to blame the most for this? Us. The so-called haves, not the have-nots.

Here's the truth about the wealth gap: the have-nots, whether in Pakistan or India or elsewhere, unfortunately, are as downtrodden and as uneducated as the have-nots anywhere else in the world. Poverty is a global issue. All poor people starve, all poor people are helpless, wherever they may be.

However, the haves – the elites, the powerful, the successful – are the ones who should be questioned for what ails us. They hold power. They call the shots. Most 'extremists' are poor. Most people who cultivate, politicize and exploit this extremism are rich.

I don't mean to sound like a socialist but Pakistan's elite lack the spine, patience and wherewithal to deal with the country. They run traffic lights in their crore-rupee cars. If they can't wait for a light to turn green, even with their Harvard and Oxford degrees, how can they expect regular folk to abide by the law? That's the tragedy of Pakistan. Nobody fixes the basics. Everyone just talks big and thinks small.

I've been blamed for being partisan. They said I took sides when I helped Imran Khan's government in their education initiative. That's wrong. I wasn't supporting Khan. I was